- Russia would benefit greatly from the repairing of Iranian infrastructure following its destruction in an Israeli attack.
- Russia would be the one to refill (for a price, of course) the Iranian weapons depots.
- Russia would benefit from the increase in energy prices after such an attack.
- Russia could—after an attack—serve as mediator between Iran and the rest of the world.

In general, Russian-US relations toward the end of 2018 seem to be closer to what they were during the Cold War era than to the short period of Trump's rise to power, during which it appeared that he and Putin would be partners in building a new global architecture.

Options, Priorities, and the Day After

The following is a list of options, in decreasing order, of possible action against Iran:

A. A diplomatic solution through negotiations could offer the Iranians incentives that would lead them to agree to cancel or freeze their nuclear project.

B. Iran might agree to a one- or two-year breakout time, when it would have enriched uranium with a high enough level of fissile material to make ten bombs. It is quite possible that the United States will concede to this. Some say that in an extreme case the United States may agree to a one-month breakout time, believing that after their first experiment the Iranians will commit to not advancing any further. The Europeans will be satisfied with either of these two options.

C. A solution through sanctions may work if a number of conditions are present: (1) the sanctions are really tough (e.g., the cessation of the sale of refined petroleum to Iran, a complete economic boycott, the termination of investments in energy development); (2) Europe is fully on board with the sanctions; (3) Russia fully joins the sanctions regime; and (4) China, while not being required to join in, does refrain from blatantly violating the sanctions. The most problematic of these